

CONCORDIA THEOLOGICAL SEMINARY

MNEMONICS IN HISTORY AND APPLICABILITY IN CATECHESIS

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Contents

Contents.....	2
I. Introduction.....	3
II. Historical Development of Mnemonics.....	4
A. Simonides of Ceos	4
B. Ad Herennium	6
III. Memory in the Old Testament	9
A. Overview of 'Remembrance' in the Old Testament.....	9
B. Deuteronomy 11:18-21	13
1. Hebrew Translation - Deuteronomy 11:18-21	13
2. Verse Commentary.....	13
3. Summary of Deuteronomy 18:18-21.....	17
IV. Memory in the Jewish School.....	18
A. Education.....	18
B. Methods of Education	21
C. Mnemonic Applications in Jewish Education	25
V. Memory in the Christian Church and Catechumenate.....	28
A. Memory in the Middle Ages	28
B. Medieval Memory Devices.....	31
VI. Luther and Lutheran Catechesis.....	34
A. Luther's Small Catechism.....	34
B. Luther's Large Catechism	35
C. Other Writings of Luther on Memory	36
VII. Modern Studies in Memory.....	38
VIII. Application of Mnemonics for Lutheran Catechesis	44
IX. Conclusion	46

I. Introduction

This essay will be divided into two main divisions. The first division of this essay will focus on the historical developments and implementations of memory devices or *mnemonics*. The second section of this paper will focus on additional information given by modern science and research to supplement the ancient techniques of mnemonics for the purpose of aiding both teacher, student and pastor in catechesis and other daily learning and duties.

The first division, under the first five headings, will give a broad survey of the history of memory techniques found in ancient literature. I will then examine the importance of memory as found in the texts of Scripture with exegesis of Deuteronomy 11:18-21 as a paradigm for remembrance for the Israelite.

From the starting point of the exhortations of Scripture 'to remember', I will demonstrate how the Hebrews, and later the Jews, would understand and implement the Scriptural exhortations to memory and remembrance found in Scripture. I will briefly show how the Church appropriated and implemented memory devices in their memory treatises in the Medieval era. In the last heading of the first division, I will review how Martin Luther approached the necessity of memory and its practice in his *Small* and *Large Catechisms* as well as his other writings.

The second half of this essay, headings seven through eight, will focus on the pragmatic implementation of mnemonics, as developed in the ancient world, and make them applicable to modern Lutheran catechesis for the benefit of both the student and the teacher. In conclusion, I will summarize and apply the modern scientific findings regarding man's memory and how they may, along with traditional *mnemotechnics*, best be utilized by the teacher or pastor in Lutheran catechesis.

II. Historical Development of Mnemonics

A. Simonides of Ceos

After being invited to a banquet to recite a poem, the poet Simonides of Ceos (556-448 B.C.), called the “honey-tongued”¹, chanted a lyric. But his host, Scopas, stated he would only pay him half of what was owed, the rest would have to be paid by the gods - to whom he dedicated half his lyric. A moment later Simonides was given a message two men were waiting outside the banquet hall for him, so Simonides went outside. Shortly after leaving the banquet hall, the roof crashed in upon Scopas and his guests, killing them all. The victims were not identifiable, yet Simonides was able to remember them *by means of recalling where they sat at the banquet*.²

This is the beginning of mnemonics – or at least the first written record we have of the art of memory. There are several notable feature of Simonides’ ability to recall the necessary information. First, the event showed him that orderly, logical arrangement was necessary for recall, “Noting that it was through his memory of the places at which the guests had been sitting that he had been able to identify the bodies, he realized that orderly arrangement is essential for good memory.”³

Second, by means of recalling the *location* of where the guests sat at Scopas’ banquet, Simonides memory was cued to recall who they were and was able to identify the bodies. Commenting on Simonides Yates says, “The first step was to imprint on the memory a series of *loci* or places.”⁴

¹ Yates, Frances Amelia. *The Art of Memory*, (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966), 27.

² Ibid., 2.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Ibid., 3.

Third, *visual* prompts are necessary for recall of information. Without Simonides' visualization of the guests, and their seating arrangement, he would not have been able to identify the bodies, "...Simonides' invention of the art of memory rested, not only on his discovery of the importance of order for memory, but also on the discovery that the sense of sight is the strongest of all the senses."⁵

Along with Simonide, Aristotle places a high value on imagery within man as a means of recollection. Yates quotes Aristotle in his work *De anima*, "Hence, 'the soul never thinks without a mental picture'; 'the thinking faculty thinks of its forms in mental pictures'; 'no one could ever learn or understand anything, if he had not the faculty of perception; even when he thinks speculatively, he must have some mental picture with which to think.'"⁶ These observations are important as they will serve as the basis for impressing the memory with images, as will be discussed under *Ad Herennium*.

While Simonides did not codify these teachings into as a treatise, a half-century later a treatise on memory called the *Dialexesis* (400 B.C.) put down the basic principles of a trained, or artificial memory.⁷ It is the earliest known work of its kind on developing an 'artificial' memory.⁸ The *Dialexesis* give three basic rules for memory: a.) pay attention b.) repeat often what you have heard, it solidifies what is heard into memory c.) to place what you hear on what you know.⁹ This third maxim points to the necessity of placing visual imagery upon *loci*.

Yates comments on the *Dialexesis*, "The skeleton outline of the rules of the artificial memory is thus already in existence about half a century after the death of Simonides. This suggests that what he 'invented', or codified, may really have been the rules, basically as we find

⁵ Ibid., 4.

⁶ Ibid., 32.

⁷ Ibid., 29.

⁸ Ibid., 30.

⁹ Ibid., 29-30.

them in *Ad Herennium*.”¹⁰ It is suggested that the art of trained memory was invented as a necessity for the student of rhetoric¹¹ for a speech was remembered, not written.

B. Ad Herennium

Apart from any other writing in the history of mnemonics and a trained memory, the *Ad Herennium* is a foundational work upon which all other written treatises on memory are built upon. Thought to have been written by Cicero or Tullius by tradition, this claim is now disputed¹², the *Ad Herennium* was written circa 86-82 B.C. as a book on rhetoric.

The author dedicates a section of his book on rhetoric to memory. The author of *Ad Herennium* declares, “...Now let us turn to the treasure-house of inventions, the custodians of all the parts of rhetoric, memory.”¹³ He continues on to state that there are two kinds of memory, one natural, the other artificial...“The artificial memory is that memory which is strengthened by a kind of training and system of discipline.”¹⁴

This book is thought to draw upon earlier Greek resources on memory training, all of which are lost – it is the only Latin treatise available from the time period available on the artificial memory.¹⁵ The *Ad Herennium* can be difficult to understand as it seems to draw upon earlier works that take for granted certain memory principles unknown to us today.¹⁶

¹⁰ Ibid., 30.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid., 17.

¹³ Ibid., 5.

¹⁴ <Cicero> *Ad C. Herennium de ratione dicendi (Rhetorica ad Herennium)*, (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1954), 207.

¹⁵ Yates, 5.

¹⁶ Ibid., 6.

Regardless, it is upon this work that all later medieval treatises on memory would be based upon, "...the astonishing developments of the art of memory in the sixteenth century...still preserve the 'Ad Herennium' outlines below all their complex accretions."¹⁷

Because of its immense value in influencing all future memory schemes for advancing artificial memory, I will give a basic outline of how the author advances artificial memory.

At the start the author differentiates between two kinds of memory, one the inborn natural memory, "and the other the product of art...The artificial memory is that memory which is strengthened by a kind of training and system of discipline."¹⁸

He then proceeds to discuss the importance of "backgrounds", that is, locations or *loci*. These places are to be arranged in a logical, sequential order that does not deviate. These backgrounds or places are to be a type of 'placeholder' for images to be stored upon. The images are those things which are to be remembered – either things (*memoria rerum*) or words (*memoria verbum*).

By establishing a fixed pattern of backgrounds or locations, new images may be placed without damaging the locations, "...for the images, like letters, are effaced when we make no use of them, but the backgrounds, like wax tablets should abide."¹⁹ These locations may be real locations, such a moving through a church and fixing locations in the memory, or entirely fictitious.²⁰

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Cicero, 207.

¹⁹ Ibid., 211.

²⁰ Ibid., 213.

The author then discusses the two types of images necessary to be placed upon the loci, memory for things and for words. Both enlist the usage of images that will ‘cue’ the desired memory.²¹

The author states that *memoria verbum* is more difficult than *memoria rerum*, stating, “...we shall be undertaking a greater task and exercising our ingenuity the more.”²² The author advocates going over verses that are to be committed to memory, “...twice or three times to ourselves and then represent the words by means of images.” By combining repetition with images the natural memory is helped and “stimulated” by the use of such means when exercising *memoria verbum*, “In this way art will supplement nature.”²³

The next section of *Ad Herennium* discusses what type of images will best be remembered. He argues, from nature, that the unusual, disfigured or striking images are most easily remembered without effort:

Now nature herself teaches us what we should do. When we see in everyday life things that are pretty, ordinary, and banal, we generally fail to remember them...But if we see or hear something exceptionally base, dishonorable, extraordinary, great, unbelievable, or laughable, that we are likely to remember a long time...Nor could this be so for any other reason that ordinary things easily slip from the memory while the striking and novel stay longer in mind.²⁴

The author of *Ad Herennium* then moves to giving advice to the instructor of the art of memory. He states that the instructor should not give all the images to the students, but rather give a few examples, and make the students conjure up their own images, suitable to what they would like to remember. For to one student one image may be striking, yet to another it leaves a

²¹ Ibid., 215.

²² Ibid., 217.

²³ Ibid.

²⁴ Ibid., 219.

vague impression, "...one person is more struck by one likeness, and another more by another...one that is well defined to us appears relatively inconspicuous to others."²⁵

The author closes this section with an admonition to hard work and effort to obtain a good memory, "In every discipline artistic theory is of little avail without unremitting exercise, but especially in mnemonics theory is almost valueless unless made good by industry, devotion, toil, and care."²⁶ The author then declares the value of memory as a practical tool in everyday life, "Indeed there is never a moment when we do not wish to commit something to memory...So, since a ready memory is a useful thing, you see clearly with what great pains we must strive to acquire so useful a faculty."²⁷

III. Memory in the Old Testament

A. Overview of 'Remembrance' in the Old Testament

'To remember', most commonly translated in the Hebrew as זָכַר, occurs in the Old Testament 232 times. This may seem insignificant, but 'remembering' occurs in .96% of all verses in the Old Testament.²⁸ While I will not argue that word occurrence determines the 'weight' of topics in Scripture, the idea of 'remembrance' is an idea the Biblical writers placed emphasis upon and did so frequently.

To further illustrate the importance of remembrance one only needs to look to the antithesis of memory – forgetting. The Hebrews were repeatedly exhorted to 'not forget' the LORD or the doctrine of the torah. The Hebrew word שָׁכַח is most commonly translated

²⁵ Ibid., 223.

²⁶ Ibid., 225.

²⁷ Ibid.

²⁸ Please see Appendix A. זָכַר may also be rendered "male" with a variant of vowel pointing.

“forget” or “forgot” occurring 102 times²⁹ or in .41% of all the verses of OT Scripture. Together with “remember” the topic of “remembrance” occurs in 1.37% of all OT Scripture.

To put these statistics into context, the term for ‘covenant’ in Hebrew, בְּרִית, occurs 284 times comprising 1.14% of OT Scripture. “To remember” and “to forget” are important, repetitive themes in OT Scripture.

I would argue that the faithful Hebrew was called to remembrance very frequently – perhaps as frequently as the Psalms were sung, chanted or meditated upon. The Psalmist took special notice of both זָכַר and שָׁכַח by his frequent repetition of these words 83 times in the Book of Psalms. “I will delight myself in your statutes; I will not forget your word.” (Ps. 119:16). I believe it is for this reason, in part, that the Jewish schools developed such a rigorous devotion to ‘learn by heart’ the Scriptures, as will be discussed in the third section of this paper.

It is of important note that the first act of remembrance in Scripture does not begin with man, but rather with God remembering man, “Then God remembered Noah, and every living thing, and all the animals that *were* with him in the ark. And God made a wind to pass over the earth, and the waters subsided.” (Gen. 8:1)

In God’s mercy to man after the flood, He did not create an invisible “spiritual” sign, but a physical reminder to man that could be visually grasped of an intangible covenant, “...and I will remember my covenant which is between Me and you...The rainbow shall be in the cloud, and I will look on it to remember the everlasting covenant...”(Gen. 9:15a, 16a)

While the text states that the rainbow is to ‘remind’ God, the sign of this covenant is meant for our benefit as God, “...will not forsake you nor destroy you, nor forget the covenant of your fathers which He swore to them.”(Dt.4:31) God’s remembrance is assured, although at

²⁹ Please see Appendix A-1.

times it may feel, according to difficult circumstances, that the LORD has forgotten His covenant people as is found in various places in Scripture.³⁰ But it is in faith that we have this assurance, “Can a woman forget her nursing child, And not have compassion on the son of her womb? Surely they may forget, Yet I will not forget you.” (Is.49:15)

Why was there such an emphasis on remembrance? For the Hebrew, it was not an act of ‘parroting’ Scripture, but in remembrance of the works of the LORD for His people in history so they would not slip into apostasy.³¹ In remembrance of the Words and works of God, the faith was passed onto the next generation, “Only take heed to yourself, and diligently keep yourself, lest you forget the things your eyes have seen, and lest they depart from your heart all the days of your life. And teach them to your children and your grandchildren.”(Dt. 4:9) The importance of memory to the Hebrew will be further discussed in the exegesis of Deuteronomy 11:18-21 which follows.

As stated earlier, according to Aristotle, man thinks in terms of *visual images*, and his memory is prompted or ‘cued’ by signs and symbols. If this is true, visible images such as the rainbow, would trigger man’s memory of God’s covenant and mercy. Luther also comments regarding the value of the physical sign of the Sacrament of Baptism, “Certainly, it should and must be external so that the senses can perceive and grasp it and it thus can be brought into the heart.”³² As created beings, God has chosen to work through physical means, namely the Sacraments.

While the Sacraments are most certainly not only symbols but efficacious means of grace, God in His loving condescension to man’s physicality has given the gift of a physical, visible sacrament that can be grasped by man’s senses. For example, in witnessing another’s

³⁰ Cf. Lam.5:20

³¹ Cf. Dt. 8:19

³² LC IV 30

baptism, we recall (our memories are ‘cued’ by this outward sign) our own baptism and its meaning. We are told explicitly by Jesus Christ that the Sacrament of His body and blood is to bring us into remembrance of Himself, “This do, as often as you drink *it*, in remembrance of Me.” (1 Cor. 11:25)

In the Old Testament, the Sacrament of circumcision was a sign cut into the flesh that would certainly bring the covenant Hebrew into remembrance. Circumcision was a sign that could not be overlooked and was seen daily – it was a sign that became part of the man receiving it. Through this mark of circumcision, the Hebrew was daily brought to remembrance by a permanent outward symbol that cued his memory of God’s covenant with him.

The Hebrews used other God appointed means to prompt their memory of Gods’ word. One such method was for the Hebrew to weave tassels into their clothes, “And you shall have the tassel, that you may look upon it and remember all the commandments of the LORD and do them, and that you may not follow the harlotry which your own heart and your own eyes are inclined.” (Num.15:39).

Of course the ritual actions of sacrifice and the Hebrew religious festivals, especially the Passover, would prompt their memory of God’s ‘*hesed*’ to His covenant people. Morris notes, “Throughout his life, from birth to death, the Jew was surrounded by an endless succession of sign and symbol ceaselessly exhorting him ‘to remember’”³³

The last mention of remembrance is given in Malachi 4:4-6. In this text, memory both looks back and forward to the coming of the Messiah, “Remember the law of Moses...Behold I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD. And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to the children...”

³³ Morris, Nathan. *The Jewish School: An Introduction to the History of Jewish Education*. (New York: Jewish Education Committee Press, 1964), 117.

B. Deuteronomy 11:18-21

In this section, I will examine the place of Israel's memory of God's words and deeds on their behalf, both in the individual and corporate life of Israel on the basis of Deuteronomy 11:18-21. This text is paradigmatic for Israel's memory of God throughout the Old Testament. It is a memory that not only looks backwards, but a memory that looks *forward*, in anticipation for the coming Messiah.

Memory and remembrance is a major theme in the book of Deuteronomy. Archer notes this theme of "remembrance" in Deuteronomy:

The characteristic admonition is: "Remember, and forget not!" Rather than embarking on some quest for "new truth" to replace the old, Israel is to retain and to obey the revealed truth which it has once and for all received from the absolute and unchanging Source of truth.³⁴

1. Hebrew Translation - Deuteronomy 11:18-21

And you will apply [place/lay up] these words of mine upon your heart and upon your inner-most being [soul] and bind them as a sign [symbol/token] upon your hand and they are frontlets between your eyes. And you will teach them to your children [sons] and speak of them [by mean of them/through them] when you sit in your house and when you walk in the way and when you lie down and when you rise. And you will write them upon the door-posts of your house and on your gates in order that *both* your days shall be many and the days of your children [sons] upon the land which YHWH swore to your fathers to give to them, like the days of the heavens upon [over] the land [earth].

2. Verse Commentary

11:18: And you will apply [place/lay up] these words of mine upon your heart and upon your inner-most being [soul] and bind them as a sign [symbol/token] upon your hand and they are frontlets between your eyes.

³⁴ Archer, Gleason L. *A Survey of Old Testament Introduction*, (Chicago: Moody Press, 1994), 273.

The ‘words’ Moses refers to ‘laying up’ or ‘applying’³⁵ (וְשִׁמְתָם) to the ‘heart and soul’ are the sum teachings of the Torah. This is for good reason, as Moses’ words are not the words of a man, but of the LORD.³⁶

This verse is an exhortation to meditation, and by extension, memorization. For the Israelite meditation was a verbal exercise (hagah), “what is spoken with the mouth is the same as ‘meditation.’”³⁷

The divisions of the Hebrew Bible – Torah, Prophets and Writings are marked by meditation. Joshua 1:8, the first book of prophets for Hebrews and Psalm 1:2, the first book of writings for the Hebrews, are both marked by an exhortation to “meditate” on the Torah.

Wilson comments, “...meditation is the key theme which binds the three divisions of the Hebrew Bible together.”³⁸ As noted above, the Old Testament ends in an exhortation to remember the torah of Moses in Malachi 4:4-6. It is fitting that both Malachi and the torah points to Christ (John 5:39) again showing a remembrance of future things to pass.

Deuteronomy 11:18-21 is often understood as a repetition or variation of Deuteronomy 6:9³⁹ which includes, “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart.” Luther notes of Deuteronomy 6:9, “You will note that Moses places this admonition, not with other Commandments but with the first one alone and with his declaration *that they be in the heart, be impressed, spoken, written, and inscribed* [emphasis mine].”⁴⁰

³⁵ Cf. BDB, s.v. שִׁמָּה

³⁶ Cf. Deut. 4:2; 5:5.

³⁷ Wilson, Marvin, *Our Father Abraham*, (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans Publishing, 1989), 154.

³⁸ Ibid.

³⁹ Driver, S. R. *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on Deuteronomy*. The International critical commentary on the Holy Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, [3], (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1902), 131.

⁴⁰ Luther, Martin *Luther's Works: Lectures on Deuteronomy* (St. Louis: CPH, 1960), 70.

While Chapter 11:18-21 may be a repetition of 6:9 ff. the ‘words’ of Moses take on a more encompassing and global view on what is to be applied to the heart – all of God’s word found in the writings of Moses.

While nowhere in this text or in 6:6-9 is there an exhortation to ‘remember’ (זָכַר), to place words in or upon the heart (עַל-לִבְבְּכֶם) is *synonymous with remembrance*. Morris writes, “To make a strong or a permanent impression on the memory is ‘to write it down on the heart,’ or on the ‘tablet of the heart.’ ... The same idea is implied in the expression ‘to blot out a memory,’ used by various biblical writers: it means wiping off the writing from the tablet of the heart.”⁴¹

The binding of the words to the hand and using them as ‘frontlets’ is metaphorical, although according to the JPS, “Many commentators suggest that the comparison refers to the practice of tying a string around the finger to remember something.”⁴² There are only three occurrences of this coupling of “binding” and “frontlets” in the OT, the first in Exodus, and the other two in Deuteronomy with regards to Moses words.

In the context of redeeming the first-born Exodus 13:16 says, "It shall be as a sign on your hand and as frontlets between your eyes, for by strength of hand the LORD brought us out of Egypt." Again, these verses indicate that by cultic actions, such as sacrifice, and the oral event of hearing act as signs of remembrance and guidance for Israel.

Frontlets would later be associated with ‘phylacteries’ by the time of Jesus (cf. Mt.23:5), but the evidence points to a symbolic understanding as correct:

A common means of identifying slaves in the ancient near east was to mark their hands and/or their foreheads. Perhaps these “frontlets” were marking

⁴¹ Morris, 122.

⁴² Tigay, Jeffrey H. *Deuteronomy = [Devarim] : the Traditional Hebrew Text with the New JPS Translation*. The JPS Torah commentary. Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1996), 79.

Israelites as the Lord's servants who were to be identified by allowing the Law to permeate their thoughts and actions... These "frontlets" were to be "memorials" on the forehead... reminding the Israelite to think upon the commandments of the Lord and to keep them.⁴³

Furthermore, "Headbands and armbands were common accessories in Syro-Palestine, though there is no graphic evidence proving Israelites wore them."⁴⁴ The LXX understands Deut. 6:8 to be a metaphor as well as some medieval Jewish commentators.

It was only toward the second temple period that the custom of phylacteries developed.⁴⁵ It seems this practice developed to prompt the memory of the Jew by means of an outward ornamentation, such as tassels on their garments (Num.15:38; Dt.22:12).

11:19-20: *And you will teach them to your children [sons] and speak of them [by mean of them/through them] when you sit in your house and when you walk in the way and when you lie down and when you rise. And you will write them upon the door-posts of your house and on your gates*

The first portion of this verse focuses on the teaching of the Torah – handed down from father to son. This teaching was done by oral repetition, "which remained the primary means of instruction in Israel even after the spread of literacy"⁴⁶, as scrolls were expensive and rare.⁴⁷ It necessitated the use of memory to pass down these teachings.

The second section of this verse is dominated by Qal infinitives – to sit, to walk, to lie down, to rise. All these mundane activities describe the everyday life of all mankind, all sanctified by God's Word – the teaching and hearing of Scripture. Luther picks up on this theme

⁴³ TWOT s.v. ttp

⁴⁴ Walton, John H., Victor Harold Matthews, and Mark W. Chavalas. *The IVP Bible Background Commentary: Old Testament*, (Downers Grove, Ill: InterVarsity Press, 2000), 177.

⁴⁵ Weinfeld, Moshe. *Deuteronomy 1-11: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*, (New York: Doubleday, 1991), 341.

⁴⁶ Tigay, 78.

⁴⁷ Morris, 120.

in his *Large Catechism*, “How then is sanctifying accomplished?...by our being occupied with God’s Word and putting it into practice.”⁴⁸

Morris notes that the activity of teaching and discussion between pupils “deepens” and “widens” knowledge ⁴⁹ which aids in memory.

11:21: in order that both your days shall be many and the days of your children [sons] upon the land which YHWH swore to your fathers to give to them, like the days of the heavens upon [over] the land [earth].

Why are the words of Torah to be committed to memory and always before the eyes of the Israelites? In order that (לְמַעַן) they would enjoy a multiplicity of days in the Promised Land – in other words a long life. “For in Scripture ‘to have long life’ does not merely mean to live many years but to have everything that should go with long life, such as health, wife and offspring, peace, good government, etc., without which this life can neither be happily enjoyed nor continue for long.”⁵⁰

While at first glance this verse seems to place a condition on Israel for entering into the Promised Land, as some commentators have mentioned, the inheritance of the land is not conditional on Israel’s obedience. Rather they will enter into the Land by the Lord’s own word which he “swore to your fathers.” It is the meek (עֲנִי) who shall inherit the land (Ps. 37:11 cf. Mt.5:5) by God’s grace because He remembers the covenant made with the Patriarchs.⁵¹

3. Summary of Deuteronomy 18:18-21

⁴⁸ LC I 88

⁴⁹ Morris, 119-120.

⁵⁰ LC I 134

⁵¹ Cf. Lev.26:42,45; Dt.8:18.

The demand for a constant awareness of “the divine message”⁵² was, as Luther notes, a reflection on the first commandment. The Israelites were, as we are, in constant danger of creating a false god – an idol of god forged in our own image.

When Moses speaks to Israel and tells them to lay up God’s word in their heart and soul, he speaks to them as having one heart, singular, and one soul, singular. There is a corporate and congregational understanding of how these words will be placed upon the hand and heart – to do and to know. These words are “laid up” in us through Worship primarily, and secondarily through individual reflection, meditation and teaching.

IV. Memory in the Jewish School

A. Education

The Jewish educational system sought to isolate itself from other cultural influences. An anecdotal story show that the Jewish community and school were not interested in propagating outside cultures, influences or educational methods inside their educational system:

...In the Talmud there is a story of a progressive young Rabbi who wished to study Greek on the grounds that he had mastered the Law. An older Rabbi reminded him of the words of Joshua: ‘This book of the Law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shall meditate therein day and night.’ ‘Go then and consider’ he said, ‘which is the hour which is neither of the day or of the night, and in it thou mayest study Greek wisdom.’⁵³

In the ancient Jewish community, education for children took a high priority.⁵⁴ Barclay goes so far as to state, “It would not be wrong to say that for the Jew the child was the most important person in the community.”⁵⁵ Examining the words of Josephus, Barclay may be

⁵² Weinfeld, 341.

⁵³ Barclay, 38.

⁵⁴ Barclay, William. *Train Up a Child; Educational Ideals in the Ancient World*. (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1959), 11.

⁵⁵ Ibid.

correct. Josephus writes, “Our ground is good, and we work it to the utmost, but our chief ambition is for the education of our children... We take most pains of all with the instruction of children, and esteem the observation of the laws, and the piety corresponding with them, the most important affair of our whole life.”⁵⁶

This dedication to education in the Jewish community made them one of the most literate communities during the time period, “So widespread and far-reaching was this education in New Testament times, that A.C. Bouquet says that it was an ‘age of the widest literacy for eighteen hundred years to come.’”⁵⁷

Because Scripture is the Divine revelation of God, the Jewish community put emphasis on learning the Scripture from an early age, “Philo writes: ‘Since Jews esteem their laws as divine revelations, and are instructed in the knowledge of them from their earliest youth, they bear the image of the Law in their souls...’”⁵⁸ The preservation of the divine writing was to be established not only on scrolls, but in the memory of every Israelite. As noted, this remembrance began at youth, “The ideal of instruction is oral teaching, and the worthiest shrine of truths that must not die is the memory and heart of the faithful disciple.”⁵⁹

The ancient Jews began the education of their children at the age of five to seven. “There is a late addendum to the fifth book of the Sayings of the Fathers, which sets out the ages of man: ‘At five years old, Scripture; at ten years, Mishnah; at thirteen, the commandments; at fifteen, Talmud...’”⁶⁰

But the Rabbis felt that a child was never too young to begin hearing, learning and being impressed with the words of Scripture, and in fact recognized that this process of learning was

⁵⁶ Josephus cited by Barclay, 12.

⁵⁷ Barclay, 14.

⁵⁸ Ibid., 12.

⁵⁹ Ibid., 23.

⁶⁰ Ibid., 34.

most beneficial at an early age, “Rabbi Abujah said: ‘He who learns as a lad, to what is he like? To ink written on fresh paper. And he who learns when he is old, to what is he like? To ink written on paper that has already been used.’”⁶¹

Even with their high value upon education in school, the true place of religious learning was to be the home.⁶² It was in the home that catechesis was to take place foremost with the father of the house teaching the children the Torah, “As soon as a child can speak (that is, after his third year) he is to be instructed in the Law by his father.”⁶³ Barclay continues, “From the fourth year it is the duty of the father to begin to initiate him into the great truths, for land and religion begin when the child can speak distinctly.”⁶⁴

The first thing a Jewish child was taught, after he was old enough to speak, were two important texts from Scripture, “As for actual instruction, as soon as he could speak the child was taught to memorise and to say the two texts: ‘Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God is one Lord,’ and, ‘Moses commanded us a law, even the inheritance of the congregation of Jacob.’”⁶⁵

In addition, when attending religious festivals, the father was to explain to his children the meaning behind the festivals and instruct them God’s graciousness as shown in history.⁶⁶ They synagogue services were also an opportunity to learn, “The characteristic word in connection with the Synagogue in the New Testament is *didaskein*, to teach.”⁶⁷

The backbone of all ancient Jewish education was Scripture alone, “It has always to be remembered that Jewish education was entirely religious education. There was no text-book except the Scriptures; all primary education was preparation for reading the Law; and all higher

⁶¹ Ibid., 35.

⁶² Ibid., 14.

⁶³ Ibid., 17.

⁶⁴ Ibid., 35.

⁶⁵ Ibid., 36.

⁶⁶ Ibid., 23.

⁶⁷ Ibid., 24.

education was the reading and the study of it.”⁶⁸ Barclay continues, “The Jews were ‘the people of the book’ not because each individual one of them possessed the book, but because the book was the container of the law of life, which was inserted into their minds, and graven upon their hearts, by oral teaching.”⁶⁹ This exemplifies what has been stated above under the exegesis of Deuteronomy 18:18-21.

Of course the learning ‘by heart’ of Scripture was no easy task, and required dedication and hard work, “The Jew never pretended that this was easy. Such knowledge was only to be won at the cost of toil. A man cannot inherit his father’s knowledge, as he might his fortune...Rabbi Joses the Priest said: ‘Give thyself trouble to learn the Law, for it is not obtained by inheritance.’”⁷⁰

B. Methods of Education

As noted previously, beginning a formal education began between the ages of five and seven. The students would enter the school and sit at the teacher feet, “...To sit at the master’s feet was a sign of the scholar’s humility, and of his eagerness to learn.”⁷¹

After learning the ‘Aleph-Bet’, the boy would continue to study the Pentateuch. A student’s study of the Bible would begin with the reading of the Shema (Deut.6,4-9. 11, 13-21. Num. 15, 37-41), and the Hallel (Psalms 113-118). Ebner notes, “These two sections constituted important parts of the liturgy and were recited either publicly at the synagogue or privately at home. Learning to read them, he would learn to know them by heart and would thus be in the

⁶⁸ Ibid., 13.

⁶⁹ Ibid., 24.

⁷⁰ Ibid., 14.

⁷¹ Ibid., 38.

position to more fully participate in the services. With regard to the Shema he would sooner be able to recite it each morning and evening, as the law required the Jew to do.”⁷²

The textbook used in school, named, *Beth Ha-Sepher*, or ‘The House of the Book’ was Scripture, “And of the sacred writings the Law, the Pentateuch was all-important, and the rest of the writings were only commentary on it.”⁷³ Quite differently from the educational system today, aside from the teachers having Scripture, books hardly existed as an educational tool for the student. “All was by word of mouth, and by patient repetition and receptive hearing.”⁷⁴ Scrolls were expensive and took a trained Scribe nearly a year to copy the Torah by hand.⁷⁵

There were two foundational aspects of the Jewish education and they both directly relate to memory. Foremost, the Jewish educational system was compromised of oral teaching, and as a consequence of this, there was much repetition. Secondly, and interrelated, was the fact that a good memory was essential for the student and a necessity for the scholar. Barclay notes that the ancient Jewish education:

...was based entirely on *oral teaching*; and therefore it was conducted entirely by repetition. The word *mishnah* itself means both *repetition* and *instruction*, for they were one and the same thing...The second basic fact is the direct consequence of this. Education was to a very large extent memorising. Since the material could not be read, it had to be committed to the memory, and therefore the first essential of a good scholar was a trained and retentive memory.⁷⁶

Learning (and reading for all ancients) always consisted of verbal recitation *aloud*. To emphasize the necessity of learning aloud, “The Talmud tells of a pupil who learned his tasks without repeating the words aloud, and who therefore had within three years forgotten all that he

⁷² Ebner, Eliezer. *Elementary Education in Ancient Israel During the Tannaitic Period (10-220 C.E.)*, (New York: Bloch Pub. Co, 1956), 77.

⁷³ Barclay, 38.

⁷⁴ *Ibid.*, 40.

⁷⁵ Wilson, 302.

⁷⁶ Barclay, 39-40.

had learned.”⁷⁷ The reason all learning and reading took place aloud was because it was believed to help in retention and comprehension, “...the student could thereby ascertain whether the ideas clear and well-arranged in his mind.”⁷⁸

Forgetfulness, as induced by quiet study is evidenced by a Rabbi’s wife rebuking a student for studying in silence. “Beruriah, the wife of R. Meir and scholarly in her own right, rebuked a student whom she had noticed studying quietly, telling him to utilize the vitality of his whole body when learning Torah. The fact, that one of the disciples of R. Eliezer forgot his learning, was explained to be the result of his habit of studying silently.”⁷⁹

The order of memorizing a text would be as follows: The teacher would recite a portion of Scripture and then make the class as a whole repeat it. When the class was able to recite the portion of Scripture together, the teacher would call on individual students, “to lead in similar fashion the responsive reading of the group.”⁸⁰

Thus for the student to learn the Torah a long series of hearing and ordered repetitions were involved that were ingrained in the Jewish tradition of school, “*The Sayings of the Fathers* lists the forty-eight things which are necessary for learning the Torah, and the list begins: ‘By learning, by a listening ear, *by ordered speech.*’ *Repetitio mater studiorum*, repetition is the mother of studies, might well have been the motto of Jewish education.”⁸¹

In opposition to today, it was not so much the quantity of what was heard and superficially ‘learned’ but in the quality of *retaining* the information. It is because of the

⁷⁷ Barclay, 41.

⁷⁸ Drazin, Nathan. *History of Jewish Education from 515 B.C.E. to 220 C.E. (During the Periods of the Second Commonwealth and the Tannaim)*, (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins press, 1940), 108.

⁷⁹ Ebner, 91.

⁸⁰ Ibid., 81.

⁸¹ Barclay, 41.

importance of Scripture that the Jewish school placed such an emphasis upon a verbatim recitation of Scripture. To hear the Torah without retaining it was like ‘sowing without reaping’.

Barclay notes the heavy emphasis on repetition, “In the Letters of Benammi certain sayings about this concentrated repetition and memorising are given. ‘If you have gathered much, you have really gathered nothing.’ ‘Repetition is the mother of knowledge.’ ‘Whosoever learns the Torah without repetition is like one who sows but does not reap.’ ‘Study not only with the eyes, but with the eyes and the mouth.’”⁸²

The importance of memory and life-time retention of Scripture for the Jews was so prominent that it was claimed that if the Talmud was forever destroyed or lost, it could be reclaimed, *verbatim*, by memory from twelve learned Rabbis.⁸³ Morris comments, “...one may say that to the Jewish teacher of Talmudic times the one and the whole meaning of method was expressed in one word – ‘memory.’”⁸⁴

Barclay notes that children were expected to master certain basic passages at school and at home: 1. the Shema 2. the Hallel (Psalms 113-18), 3. The creation story (Gen. 1-5), 4. the essential Levitical law (1-8).⁸⁵

In addition to these texts, a child had to learn a ‘personal text’. “A personal text was a text which began with the first letter of his name and ended with the last letter of his name...a boy named *Abner* could have his personal text: A soft answer turneth away wrath: But greivous words stir up anger.”⁸⁶ A common practice was for adults to ask children, ‘Tell me your verse’ which referred to what they had learned that day.⁸⁷

⁸² Ibid., 41.

⁸³ Ibid., 40-41.

⁸⁴ Morris, 121.

⁸⁵ Barclay., 42.

⁸⁶ Ibid., 42-43.

⁸⁷ Ibid., 79.

C. Mnemonic Applications in Jewish Education

With such a demand on memory, there were ingenious memory devices and aids invented to aid in the memorization of the Torah and oral law. One such aid was involving the whole body in learning – it was thought that movement, or swaying, was a mechanical aid to memorizing.⁸⁸

In the Palestinian Talmud, there are two stories that help students remember the Aleph-Bet and incorporate moral teaching into learning the Hebrew consonant, “The shape of the letters, wherever possible, is used as a mnemonic device to help the children retain the appearance and order of the letters as well as to remind them of the moral message.” We will see this technique reappear in Medieval memory treatises which they called ‘visual alphabets’.

This method of memorization reinforced the so-called ‘natural memory’ with the imagery of ‘artificial memory’ and meet with the wide approval of Rabbis of the time.⁸⁹ Ebner goes on to say that ‘spin-off’ methods were developed from this mnemonic device, “...The elementary teacher in Athens also tried to facilitate the learning of the alpha beta through dramatizing it. He would teach it in the form of a song, or devise some guessing game that was based upon the shape of the letters.”⁹⁰

As noted above, after mastery of the ‘aleph bet’ the student was brought into reading the Pentateuch. “The difficulty he now faced was how to pronounce words that were made up of consonantal letters only. There were no vowels to help him. Nor he could tell where a verse began or ended, except at the end of the whole passages, as the scroll had no signs or dividing spaces between the sentences.”⁹¹ The only way for the students to learn to read the Scripture was

⁸⁸ Morris, 139.

⁸⁹ Ebner, 90.

⁹⁰ Ibid.

⁹¹ Ibid.

to have the teacher recite the passage and have it recited back by the class. The lesson was generally recited to the student four times, or until the student had learned it.⁹² To make matters more challenging, according to tradition, verses could not be broken up, but had to be read aloud in their entirety.⁹³

One method utilized by teachers was a system of chanting or intonation to help the students remember their verses called 'Pisuk Ta'amim', "The origin of this system is reported to go back to very early times and its knowledge was transmitted orally...The employment of melody...served a twofold purpose - it appealed to the esthetic sense, making for a greater appreciation of the Bible and it impressed more effectively the content upon the memory of the learner and listener."⁹⁴

The introduction of vowel pointing in the Hebrew text of Scripture, between the times of 500 -1000 A.D.⁹⁵, is a mnemonic device employed to help students recall the proper recitation of Scripture. Morris states, "It is also suggested that the Hebrew vowel system - in its nature a system of mnemonics - had its origin in the mnemonic signs devised by the elementary schoolmaster as an 'aid' to his pupils."⁹⁶

The Rabbis also attempted to arouse interest in the subject⁹⁷ and favored having students learn and study texts that they were interested in – an interest in any subject helps memory retention as will be discussed under heading VII of this essay. "People were advised that in

⁹² Ibid., 91.

⁹³ Ibid., 90-91.

⁹⁴ Ibid., 91.

⁹⁵ Kelley, Page H., Terry L. Burden, Timothy G. Crawford, and Page H. Kelley. *A handbook to Biblical Hebrew: an introductory grammar*, (Grand Rapids, Mich: W.B. Eerdmans, 1994), 2.

⁹⁶ Morris, 138.

⁹⁷ Ibid., 144.

studying the Torah they should choose those topics that had a special interest for them, 'that their heart desired.'"⁹⁸

It is significant that the heart is mentioned, for the Jews believed, as did Aristotle, that memory resided in the heart.⁹⁹ Such an idea was itself taken from Scripture. To reiterate Morris, comments, "'Remembering' or 'recalling', is in the Bible frequently synonymous with 'coming up to' or 'putting into' the heart. And conversely, to 'forget' or 'be forgotten' is equivalent to 'departing' or 'removing' from the heart.'"¹⁰⁰

As the heart was thought to be the house of memory, Jews believed food could affect this faculty - olives were bad, but olive oil was good! They thought that bread baked on coals was also good for memory.¹⁰¹

In the end, for the Jewish teacher and student, the greatest asset to retaining Scripture 'by heart' was by frequent review of the material¹⁰² and by not rushing from one subject to the next too quickly, "...to study continuously new subjects, without making sure that the old ones are not forgotten, would nearly defeat its own purpose. In so doing one would resemble 'a man who sows but does not reap,' or as another Tanna puts it: 'a woman who bears children and buries them.'"¹⁰³

Time was given to the students to reflect and ruminate upon their lessons, "The Rabbis were very emphatic in this advise. They explained that when God taught Moses the Law, He also paused after every section and after every subject."¹⁰⁴

⁹⁸ Drazin, 108.

⁹⁹ Morris, 121.

¹⁰⁰ Ibid., 122.

¹⁰¹ Ibid., 123.

¹⁰² Ebner, 92.

¹⁰³ Ibid., 93.

¹⁰⁴ Drazin, 114.

While care was taken not to move too quickly from one subject to the next before its mastery, a method found helpful was to study different subjects that had one common theme, "In order to facilitate memorization the Rabbis...oftentimes combined the study of many different subjects that had one common feature."¹⁰⁵

While there were no set rules for the amount of times a lesson should be reviewed by a student, the general consensus among teachers was, 'the more the better'.¹⁰⁶ Some took symbolic numbers from Scripture as a standard, such as forty times, as many days as Moses was upon Mt. Sinai.¹⁰⁷ Others reviewed 24 times, as many books in the Hebrew Cannon.¹⁰⁸ Morris comments on using forty repetitions, "It was apparently believed that there was a particular efficacy in this latter number, for we find many references to it."¹⁰⁹

This method of constant repetition was thought by the Rabbis to aid in retention, "...but also produced greater clarity."¹¹⁰

V. Memory in the Christian Church and Catechumenate

A. Memory in the Middle Ages

In the fifth century a work written by Marianus Capella, *De nuptiis Philologiae et Mercurii* ensured the survival of the ancient art of memory. It was a book on the seven liberal arts that contained a section on artificial memory.¹¹¹ Yet even without this work Christian theologians of

¹⁰⁵ Ibid., 115.

¹⁰⁶ Ebner, 93.

¹⁰⁷ Ibid., 93.

¹⁰⁸ Ibid., 93.

¹⁰⁹ Morris, 131.

¹¹⁰ Drazin, 112.

¹¹¹ Yates, 50.

that time, including Jerome and Augustine, would have been aware of the art of memory through the *Ad Herennium* as this book was known in North Africa at the time.¹¹²

It is during the time of the Middle Ages that, “In the barbarised world, the voices of the orators were silenced... Learning retreated into the monasteries and the art of memory for rhetorical purposes became unnecessary...”¹¹³ In this time period of the Middle Ages, rhetoric was not primarily the object of memory but rather, “...the things belonging to salvation or damnation, the articles of faith, the roads to heaven through virtues and to hell through vices.”¹¹⁴ The art of memory had moved its center from rhetoric to moral theology.¹¹⁵

As evidence of familiarity with the art of memory in the Church, we find in Ambrose’s catechesis a memory aid which helps his catechumens learn the Apostle’s Creed via a mnemonic device saying, “For just as there are twelve Apostles, so are there twelve phrases.”¹¹⁶ He also exhorts his catechumens to recite the Creed daily.¹¹⁷

Likewise, Augustine used mnemonic devices that he would have known from previous rhetoric training (which included artificial memory). For instance, Augustine would use repetition of biblical phrases to pound “...into the memory, as gravel is pounded into a path, to make sure that they do not pass out of the mind.”¹¹⁸

When preaching Augustine also used rhetorical devices that would help his hearers remember what he preached, “...Augustine used to make his messages memorable: metaphors, paradoxes, antitheses, puns, tongue-twisters, knotty problems, soliloquiest.”¹¹⁹ In addition,

¹¹² Ibid.

¹¹³ Yates., 53.

¹¹⁴ Ibid., 55.

¹¹⁵ Ibid., 57.

¹¹⁶ Ambrose, *Explanatio symboli* 4, quoted in William Harmless, *Augustine and the Catechumenate*, (Collegeville: The Liturgical Press, 1995), 98.

¹¹⁷ Ibid.

¹¹⁸ Augustine, *De civitate Dei* 22.8, quoted in *Augustine and the Catechumenate*, 183.

¹¹⁹ Harmless, 223.

Augustine would always review key points from his previous sermon to refresh his hearers memory.¹²⁰ Augustine also realized the power of imagery and “..focus[ed] especially on scriptural images that lay close to his hearers’ experience.”¹²¹ As we will see, Luther pursues the same technique in the writing of his *Small Catechism*.

Similar to the Jews, Augustine required his catechumens to recite back the Creed eight days before Easter, “Augustine would test them individually to see if each could recite it exactly as it had been given.”¹²²

Akin to Ambrose’s mnemonic device to aid in the learning of the Creed, Augustine would introduce a help in learning the Lord’s Prayer, “Of the seven petitions, three refer to life eternal, for to life here and now.”¹²³

In Augustine’s *On Christian Teaching*, he exhorts that the preachers first task is, “...to know these books [Scripture]; not necessarily to understand them but to read them so as to *commit them to memory* [emphasis mine] or at least make them not totally unfamiliar.”¹²⁴

Those who countered the arguments against developing an artificial memory were countered by arguments that the Scripture themselves contain many examples of ‘artificial memory’, “...for example, the cock-crow reminded Peter of something, and this was a ‘memory sign’”¹²⁵ Yates comments, “...Scriptures use poetic metaphors and speak of spiritual things under the similitudes of corporeal things.”¹²⁶

One of the most prominent theological figures of the later Middle Ages, Thomas Aquinas, is said to have an extraordinary memory which he trained under Albertus Magnus at

¹²⁰ Ibid.

¹²¹ Ibid., 224.

¹²² Ibid., 275.

¹²³ Augustine, Sermon 59.8, quoted in *Augustine and the Catechumenate*, 289.

¹²⁴ Augustine, *On Christian Teaching*, (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), 37.

¹²⁵ Ibid., 59.

¹²⁶ Ibid., 96.

Cologne.¹²⁷ Aquinas comments that it is difficult for man to remember spiritual things without images¹²⁸ and offers advice on how to memorize in his *Summa Theologiae*.

In Aquinas' *Summa Theologiae* he discusses memory, and offers "four aids to cultivating a good memory."¹²⁹ In this work Aquinas offers four observations about memory that echo the *Ad Herennium*.

In Aquinas' *Summa* he speaks about aids to memory, which are summarized as follows:

a.) To remember, one must pick unusual images, "...because simple and spiritual ideas slip somewhat easily out of mind unless they are tied, as it were, to bodily images; human knowledge has more mastery over objects of sense."¹³⁰ b.) Those things which are to be remembered are to be arranged in an orderly fashion. c.) A person must diligently want to remember the material he seeks to retain, "...because the more deeply stamped they are on the mind the less likely are they to disappear."¹³¹ d.) Frequent repetition or review of material that is desired to be retained in memory, "...the things we often think about are quickly recalled by a sort of instinctive process."¹³²

B. Medieval Memory Devices

Moving into scholastic theology, there was an increased need for the art of memory as knowledge increased. The schemes of moral theology became more complex and more rules were placed upon man for salvation in the Medieval Church which placed a new emphasis on memory.¹³³ Yates comments, "...the principles of artificial memory, as understood in the Middle Ages, would stimulate the intense visualization of many similitudes in the intense effort

¹²⁷ Yates., 70.

¹²⁸ Ibid., 71.

¹²⁹ *Summa Theologiae*, 2a2ae. 49, 1

¹³⁰ Ibid.

¹³¹ Ibid.

¹³² Ibid.

¹³³ Yates, 84.

to hold in memory the scheme of salvation, and the complex network of virtues and vices and their rewards and punishments...”¹³⁴

At this time, monks in the monastery were required to learn, by heart, all the Psalms, as evidenced by *The Rule of Ferreolus*.¹³⁵ This task, “...commonly took two to three years, though gifted individuals could manage it in six months.”¹³⁶

Yates also suggests that some of the art coming out of this period may be the result of the mnemonic principle to devise images that are shocking or unusual, such as Dante’s *Inferno*.¹³⁷ It is an interesting proposition to consider that memory plays a role in, “...the strange figures to be seen on the pages of manuscripts and in all forms of mediaeval art [are] not so much the revelation of a tortured psychology as evidence that the Middle Ages, when men had to remember, followed classical rules for making memorable images...”¹³⁸

The greatest proponents for a trained memory at this time would be the Order of Preachers – the Dominicans.¹³⁹ As the art of memory originated with rhetoric, it had now again come full circle for preaching. The Dominicans realized that, “To make people remember things, preach them to them in ‘unusual’ similitudes for these will stick better in the memory than the spiritual intentions will do, unless clothed in such similitudes.”¹⁴⁰

It is during this time period that memory treatises began to be written in the common language and not in Latin, “This suggests that the artificial memory was coming out into the world, was being recommended to laymen as a devotional exercise.”¹⁴¹

¹³⁴ Ibid., 95.

¹³⁵ Carthurs, Mary. *The Book of Memory*, (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008), 112.

¹³⁶ Ibid.

¹³⁷ Ibid.

¹³⁸ Ibid., 104.

¹³⁹ Ibid., 85.

¹⁴⁰ Ibid., 86.

¹⁴¹ Ibid., 89.

The Phoenix, written by Peter of Ravenna in Venice, 1491 was a memory book for the laity. Yates claims, “Peter laicized and popularized memory and emphasized the purely mnemotechnical side.”¹⁴²

This book became, “...the most universally known of all the memory text books,”¹⁴³ in his time. His method is based upon fixing *loci* (such as found in the *Ad Herennium*), using a familiar place, like a frequented church, and committing the places to memory, “He chooses his first place near the door; the next, five or six feet further in; and so on.”¹⁴⁴ He then places images of the things he desires to remember upon those *loci*.

Another notable mnemonic development of this age was the ‘visual alphabets’, “Visual alphabets are ways of representing letters of the alphabet by images...The visual alphabet probably comes out of endeavours to understand *Ad Herennium* on how proficient in artificial memory write in images in their memories. According to the general principles of artificial memory we should put everything that we want to fix in memory into an image.”¹⁴⁵

A further development of these ‘visual alphabets’ is in placing images for words to be recalled upon the original image or more images on top of the original image to help recall more specifics. An example of this is found in an anonymous blockbook published in South Germany in 1470 entitled, “A Method for Recollecting the Gospels”¹⁴⁶ In this book traditional graphic representations of the Gospels are given with additional images placed on top in order to help the reader recall important information about each Gospel book.

¹⁴² Ibid., 113-114.

¹⁴³ Ibid., 112.

¹⁴⁴ Ibid., 113.

¹⁴⁵ Ibid., 118, 119. See also Appendix B, Fig.1.

¹⁴⁶ *The Medieval Craft of Memory*, ed. Mary Carruthers and Jan Ziolkowski, (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2002), 255.

Yet, by the sixteenth century, the art of memory seems to be "...dwindling into curious memory games. Modern trends in humanist scholarship and education are luke warm about th classical art, or increasing hostile to it."¹⁴⁷ In fact, "Melanchthon forbids students to use any mnemotechnical devices and enjoins learning by heart in the normal was as the sole art of memory."¹⁴⁸

VI. Luther and Lutheran Catechesis

A. Luther's Small Catechism

In the Preface to Luther's Small Catechism, he makes it know that in catechesis changes to the texts that are to be committed to memory should be avoided, "In the first place, the preacher should above all take care to avoid changes in the text...instead adopt a single version, stick with it , and always use the same one year after year."¹⁴⁹ Luther continues to state the reason, "Otherwise...the people become quite easily confused, and all the time and effort will go to naught."¹⁵⁰ It is in this method that the students are to learn the Ten Commandments, the Creed and the Lord's Prayer, "...following the text word for word, so that they can also repeat it back to you and learn it by heart."¹⁵¹

Luther next emphasizes that the texts are to be memorized *first*, and then they are to be taught to understand what it means.¹⁵² Luther states that once the Small Catechism is learnt, "...then take up a longer catechism and impart to them a richer and fuller understanding."¹⁵³

¹⁴⁷ Yates, 127.

¹⁴⁸ Ibid.

¹⁴⁹ SC Preface 7

¹⁵⁰ Ibid.

¹⁵¹ SC Preface 10

¹⁵² SC Preface 14

¹⁵³ SC Preface 17

While these texts are generally well known in Lutheran circles, I bear them out because it will be seen in the following section that these methods of pedagogy and memory have been validated by modern research in the area of memory. It should also be noted that Luther's principles of catechizing are very similar to the methods employed by the ancient Jews in learning the Torah and oral law.

B. Luther's Large Catechism

In Luther's 1530 Preface to his *Large Catechism* he demonstrates his own method of learning and reinforcing his memory with the catechism. "Nevertheless, each morning, and whenever else I have time, I do as a child who is being taught the catechisms and I read and recite word for word the Lord's Prayer, the Ten Commandments, the Creed, Psalms, etc. I must still read and study the catechism daily, and yet I cannot master it as I wish..."¹⁵⁴

Note that not only does Luther read, but he read as the ancients, aloud. This reinforced his memory with his catechetical studies and as noted is characteristic of ancient Hebrew meditation. Note also it was a *daily* endeavor – repetition is necessary, as the Jews very well understood and drilled their students to learn by heart the Torah.

What does such repetition accomplish? "In such reading, conversation, and meditation the Holy Spirit is present and bestows ever new and greater light and devotion..."¹⁵⁵

In Luther's shorter Preface to his *Large Catechism* of 1529 he states that it is, "...the duty of every head of household at least once a week to examine the children and servants one after the other and ascertain what they know or have learned of it, and if they do not know it, to keep

¹⁵⁴ LC 1530 Preface 7-8

¹⁵⁵ LC 1530 Preface 9

them faithfully at it.”¹⁵⁶ This is reminiscent of the ancient Jews asking their students and children, ‘Tell me your verse.’

C. Other Writings of Luther on Memory

While Luther himself may not have employed the artificial memory or recommended it to his students, he was certainly aware of it and used many of the time tested methods popularized in various treatises of memory through the ages. Arand comments, “In addition to learning by repetition, an oral population must clothe truths in words that are memorable or that relate to each other through mnemonic devices.”¹⁵⁷

In a striking quote Luther reiterates what Aristotle said about memory and man’s necessity to think in images. Luther states, “Without images we can neither think no understand anything.”¹⁵⁸ And Luther would employ these images to help others retain his teachings found in the Small Catechism.

Arand notes the ‘word images’ employed by Luther:

Because images linger in the memory, oral speech often employs concrete terms rather than abstract concepts...words that can be pictured in the mind....where Luther could have used a more abstract term like ‘family’, he writes ‘wife and child.’ Instead of writing ‘economic livelihood’ he speaks of field and cattle...Luther’s explanations might be called *Kleinmalerei*, that is, vivid miniature word paintings.¹⁵⁹

Another memory aid Luther used in both his Catechisms were the use of woodcuts for children and the ‘simple’. Luther states, “Children and simple people are most apt to retain the divine stories when taught by picture and parable than merely by words or instruction.”¹⁶⁰

¹⁵⁶ Preface 4

¹⁵⁷ Arand, Charles P., *That I May Be His Own*, (St. Louis: Concordia Publishing House, 200), 104.

¹⁵⁸ Luther, WA:37:63 quoted by Charles P. Arand, *That I May Be His Own*, 108.

¹⁵⁹ Arand, 105.

¹⁶⁰ Luther, LW 43:43 quoted by Charles P. Arand, *That I May Be His Own*, 107.

Furthermore, Luther's familiarity with the 'art of memory' can be proven by his familiarity with Quintilian's *Institutio oratoria*, a first century book on rhetoric that included a prominent section on artificial memory.¹⁶¹ Luther cites Quintilian's work in several of his writings, most prominent are *Against Latomus*¹⁶² and *The Bondage of the Will*.

It is in *The Bondage of the Will* that Luther shows himself familiar with Quintilian's rules for memory, "Suppose Quintilian, proposing to write about oratory, were to say: "In my judgment, that stupid and superfluous stuff about choice of subject, arrangement of material, style, *memorization* [emphasis mine], delivery, ought to be omitted..."¹⁶³

Luther himself was noted to have a tremendous memory as evidenced by his knowledge of Scripture and the classics. In the Preface of Luther's commentary on Genesis we read, "Luther had an astonishingly retentive memory, as his Biblical quotations show. He had also read around in the classics and knew some classical works almost by heart."¹⁶⁴ By Luther's own account, he states that he had much of Scripture memorized, "I had then already read and taught the sacred Scriptures most diligently privately and publicly for seven years, so that I knew them nearly all by memory."¹⁶⁵

In discussing the necessary qualities of a preacher, Luther declares, "The person who wishes to preach needs to have a good voice, good eloquence, *a good memory* [emphasis mine] and other natural gifts; whoever does not have these should properly keep still and let somebody else speak."¹⁶⁶

¹⁶¹ Yates, 21.

¹⁶² Cf. Luther, Martin: Pelikan, Jaroslav Jan (Hrsg.) ; Oswald, Hilton C. (Hrsg.) ; Lehmann, Helmut T. (Hrsg.): *Luther's Works, Vol. 32 : Career of the Reformer II*, (Philadelphia : Fortress Press, 1999), 234.

¹⁶³ Luther, *Luther's Works, Vol. 33 : Career of the Reformer III*, 36.

¹⁶⁴ Luther, *Luther's Works, Vol. 1 : Lectures on Genesis: Chapters 1-5*, 1.

¹⁶⁵ Luther, *Luther's Works, Vol. 34 : Career of the Reformer IV*, 334.

¹⁶⁶ Luther, *Luther's Works, Vol. 36 : Word and Sacrament II*, 152.

Luther also follows the Jewish and Medieval practice of having students cite their memory work individually after having learned it in a group setting, “This order should be followed: The schoolmaster shall have the whole division come up for recitation, asking each pupil in turn to repeat the Lord’s Prayer, the Creed, and the Ten Commandments.”¹⁶⁷ Luther continues on and advises the memorization of a few easy Psalms for students, “Furthermore the teachers should ask the pupils to memorize a number of easy Psalms that contain in themselves a summary of the Christian life and speak about the fear of God, faith and good works...”¹⁶⁸

VII. Modern Studies in Memory

Much of the modern research in the area of memory has provided new information on how the human brain processes information and has given new physiological insights into the human brain. Yet despite this fact, modern medicine and science has offered little new practical advice on how to memorize or retain information that has not been known for centuries by the ancients. For instance, Gluck’s 2008 book, *Learning and Memory*, a college level text, gives ten tips to improving memory – only three of the ten tips are taken outside the explicit teaching of ancient memory treatises.¹⁶⁹

It is not within the scope of this essay to examine the findings of modern research on human memory and modern theories of memory. Rather, I will share what modern research has ‘discovered’ (perhaps more aptly ‘re-discovered’ as much of it was in place by 400 B.C.) and what practical applications these insights offer for improving the memory of both the student and teacher.

¹⁶⁷ Luther, *Luther's Works*, Vol. 40 : *Church and Ministry II*, 318.

¹⁶⁸ Ibid.

¹⁶⁹ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers. *Learning and Memory: From Brain to Behavior*, (New York: Worth Publishers, 2008), 3.

Generally, memory is now classified as either 'Episodic Memory' which is autobiographical memory or 'Semantic Memory', that is memory of facts and general information.¹⁷⁰ "It is more like dictionary or encyclopedic knowledge. It includes facts, words, language and grammar."¹⁷¹ The concern of this paper is to focus on research improving 'semantic memory'.

There are three accepted 'memory stages' first, memory must be encoded (put into memory). Secondly, memory must be retained (kept in memory) and thirdly, memory must be recalled.¹⁷²

According to one theory, memorized new information is stored in either short term memory (STM) or long-term memory (LTM).¹⁷³ STM is generally short, lasting only 15-30 seconds without rehearsing the information.¹⁷⁴ "Short-term memory is a halfway station of sorts, where new information stops for a while before moving on to long-term memory storage. The main idea portrayed in this model is that information in short-term memory must be maintained by active rehearsal but can be displaced by new information or distractions..."¹⁷⁵ George Miller in the 1950's discovered the capacity of the short term memory is 5-9 items. Averaged to 7 and was called the "Magic Number 7"¹⁷⁶

Long-term memory is considered more permanent, and not susceptible to loss (except for a temporary inability to recall).¹⁷⁷ "In contrast to STM, long-term store is relatively permanent. There are several types of information retained in our permanent memory, such as autobiographical memories, factual knowledge, and various skills and habits, which suggest to

¹⁷⁰ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers, 84.

¹⁷¹ Terry, Scott. *Learning and Memory*, (Boston: Pearson Education, 2000), 199.

¹⁷² Ibid., 88.

¹⁷³ Terry, 197.

¹⁷⁴ Ibid.

¹⁷⁵ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers, 172.

¹⁷⁶ Ibid., 171.

¹⁷⁷ Terry, 197.

theorists that LTM itself is made up of several separate memory components.”¹⁷⁸ It is thought that rehearsal of information in the STM transfers the information into LTM, “Specifically, rehearsal in STM keeps information available longer for encoding into LTM. The more you rehearse a phone number in STM, the better you should remember it in LTM.”¹⁷⁹

One major factor in improving memory is to strive for a greater ‘depth of processing’. “...the more deeply you analyze information, the more likely you are to encode the information in memory - and the more likely you are to remember it later.”¹⁸⁰ ‘Depth of processing’ is perhaps the greatest positive influence in memory that modern research has confirmed:

The more actively you go about processing new information. The more actively you go about processing new information, by applying it in meaningful ways, the more likely you are to remember it. In contrast, passive rehearsal through repetition has very little effect on whether or not information is later recalled from long-term memory. Thus, while passive rehearsal is good for keeping information in short-term memory, Craik and Taulving argued that it is not sufficient for transferring the information along to the long-term memory.¹⁸¹

In fact, it has been proposed, that forgetting is due to ‘shallow processing’, “Sustained retention is due not to transfer from one memory store to another, but rather to deeper or more elaborate processing.”¹⁸² A simple means of getting students to process new information more deeply is to simply ask for elaboration. Ask, ‘Why is this?’¹⁸³ In addition, if new information can be related to previous knowledge, the new information is more likely to be retained.¹⁸⁴

¹⁷⁸ Ibid., 199.

¹⁷⁹ Ibid., 197.

¹⁸⁰ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers, 90.

¹⁸¹ Ibid., 172.

¹⁸² Terry, 210.

¹⁸³ Ibid., 293.

¹⁸⁴ Ibid., 263.

It is also agreed that sleep is necessary to consolidate information and transference of short-term memory into long-term memory.¹⁸⁵ Withholding yourself from sleep to 'cram' for an exam actually has negative effects.

The 'Transfer-Appropriate Processing' principle states that, "...retrieval is more likely if the cues available at recall are similar to those that were available at encoding...Performance is worse when the encoding and testing formats differ."¹⁸⁶ An example of this would be showing words and testing with pictures, or vice versa. Therefore the best way to process new information is to do so in a way that is similar to the way you will be tested upon the material.¹⁸⁷

One reason for memory failure is 'Interference', or overlapping memories.¹⁸⁸ This interference may be 'Proactive Interference' (old information disrupting new information; PRevious information disrupts new info) or 'Retroactive Interference' (new information disrupts old information; REcently acquired information disrupts).¹⁸⁹

Dr. Ebbinghaus, a German 19th century scholar, published "On Memory" in 1885. In this often referred to study, Ebbinghaus memorized lists and recorded how much 'memory loss' occurred after learning the list. After only an hour, there was only an approximate 40% recall (for example, after memorizing a list of ten items, only four could be recalled one hour later). After one day, 34% recall.¹⁹⁰

Research into memory has given some new valuable insights into helping students move new information into the LTM. I will briefly touch on the most important. As mentioned

¹⁸⁵ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers, 279.

¹⁸⁶ Ibid., 93.

¹⁸⁷ Ibid., 94.

¹⁸⁸ Ibid., 96.

¹⁸⁹ Ibid., 96.

¹⁹⁰ Terry, 160-161.

elaboration is helpful to encode memory, there are three aspects of elaboration: effort, meaningfulness and active rehearsal.¹⁹¹

Another factor is *meaningfulness*, "...meaningful material was remembered better than the non-meaningful, a conclusion that has been repeated for 100 years now."¹⁹² Part of 'meaningfulness' is connecting old knowledge to new, "...use existing knowledge to make new information more meaningful...attempt to create meaningfulness in otherwise unfamiliar material."¹⁹³ (e.g. look for patterns in numbers, etc.). An example of this is found in a gifted language mnemonist, "He readily picks up words in new languages, mainly by looking for similar-looking or sounding words in other languages with which he is familiar."¹⁹⁴

When teaching, *avoid* going off on multiple 'tangents' called *seductive details*.¹⁹⁵ This may actually impair the hearers ability to recall the main thrust of the teaching, "Why do seductive details impair recall? One possibility is that they distract attention away from the main ideas of the text or lecture. Processing tangential facts comes at a cost to processing other information...The coherence of the material may be interrupted, and the student may not be able to organize the ideas."¹⁹⁶

Review of newly learned material should not be 'massed' but rather spaced (or distributed) out at regular intervals to help move information from the STM to LTM.¹⁹⁷ There is an exception to this rule – if information is to be retrieved shortly after learning it, 'mass' review may be preferred. A practical application of this knowledge is introduced by Terry:

One can arrange a situation to make learning appear to be easy or one could arrange it to make learning lasting...Practicing a single fact or skill in a

¹⁹¹ Ibid., 266.

¹⁹² Ibid., 268.

¹⁹³ Ibid., 269.

¹⁹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁹⁵ Ibid., 272.

¹⁹⁶ Ibid., 273.

¹⁹⁷ Ibid., 273-275

massed fashion should lead to rapid improvement...Intermixing the facts or skills in the practice sequence will slow learning, as you apparently forget from one trial to the next. Yet in the long run, learning and transfer will be increased by intermixing rather than massing the study items...¹⁹⁸

Interest in the subject is also another important aspect of memory, and modern research confirms this principle found in the art of memory. "People with interest in certain topics seem to readily acquire new information within that domain. Some of this is because prior knowledge facilitates acquiring new knowledge. Experts more easily acquire new information in their field of expertise than do novices."¹⁹⁹

In conclusion, developing a powerful memory may not be as dependent upon 'natural memory' as much as the ancients may have believed. A recent 2003 study showed:

Most world-class memory performers use mnemonics of one source or another. A recent neuroimaging study of exceptional memorizers found no differences in brain anatomy between world class memory performers and people with average memories...The implication is that almost could attain a 'world-class memory' by mastering the right techniques, such as a mnemonic system.²⁰⁰

There is a twofold benefit to using mnemonics and developing a faculty of artificial memory. First, an overall improvement in recalling and retaining information, "A study by Roediger in 1980 showed that college student who used a form of mnemonics...to memorize a 20 word list showed a dramatic increase in recall one day later over those who did not use any mnemonic."²⁰¹ Secondly, as noted, deeper processing helps ensure survival of memory into the long term memory.

¹⁹⁸ Ibid., 276.

¹⁹⁹ Ibid., 280.

²⁰⁰ Gluck, Mark, Eduardo Mercado and Catherine Myers, 95.

²⁰¹ Terry, 188.

Perhaps the greatest pedagogical benefit of using a form of mnemonics is that, "...users claim that the mnemonics make learning more enjoyable and interesting, factors that would contribute to their use and maintenance..."²⁰²

VIII. Application of Mnemonics for Lutheran Catechesis

While the ancient system of first memorizing a set of *Loci* and then placing images upon those places of the things desired to be remembered, it may be overly taxing to the average student.

Harry Lorayne popularized a system of mnemonics based on the ancient *loci* method in the 1970's. Instead of first memorizing a set of places, Lorayne realized that the things themselves could be used a loci, thus eliminating a step.²⁰³ The idea behind Harry Lorayne's system is that any new information may be remembered *if it associated with something you already know*.²⁰⁴ Pairing what is desired to be remembered *in some absurd visual manner in the imagination*.

This principle is according to ancient memory rules, and is the basis of his work of which he calls 'linking'.²⁰⁵ Item 1 is associated (or 'linked') with item 2 in an absurd manner, then item two is 'linked' with item 3 and so on. This process may be used to memorize a vast amount of items in relatively short time, very accurately. As Aristotle (and Luther) posited, in order for man to think, he must use imagery. This mnemonic technique simply takes advantage of that assumed premise.

²⁰² Ibid., 189.

²⁰³ Lorayne, Harry, and Jerry Lucas, *The Memory Book*, (New York: Ballantine Books, 1974), 24-25.

²⁰⁴ Ibid., 23.

²⁰⁵ Ibid., 31.

I will give a brief example of how to use this mnemonic device in Catechesis. If a student were given the task to remember what God gives in the first article of the Creed he would first have to remember the list starts with 'clothing'. Clothing is then linked with shoes. Perhaps the student sees himself dressed in a shirt man of shoes. *The previous item is then ignored* – it is not a running narrative. Now, 'shoes' is linked or associated with the third item, 'food'. Perhaps the student can visualize himself eating thousands of pairs of shoes from the dinner table.

This process continues until the list of ten items are complete from the first article of the Creed. Once memorized in this fashion, *the list may easily be recalled forwards or backwards* on the basis of recalling one image to the next. As noted in *Ad Herennium*, it is best for the teacher to give a few examples, but then allow the students to come up with their own images that they find absurd or striking. The idea is to create visual images that are *illogical*.

Having experimented with Loryane's system for a number of years, the process is quick and works well, but the information must be reviewed periodically to be retained. What happens in using this method of artificial memory is that if the information is review periodically the absurd imagery fades away and the information moves from what the ancients referenced as the 'artificial memory' into the 'natural memory'. That is to say, it moves from the STM into LTM.

As noted above, mnemonics makes 'route' memory more enjoyable to the student. This process of 'linking' items makes learning a seemingly boring list into an imaginative and enjoyable process. More importantly, it forces the student to elaborate and deeply process the information, which in itself leads to a better encoding in the memory.

As discussed in this essay, concrete things are more easily remembered than intangibles. So what happens when we want to recall an intangible, such as faith or love? Concrete images that remind the student of those abstracts are to be visualized. This is an important concept as

memorization of the Catechism is part of the more difficult memory process of ‘memory for words’.

To memorize verbatim the *Small Catechism* all ‘keywords’ that represent the main ideas from the appropriate section of the Catechism should first be visualized and linked. Once the keywords are memorized in this fashion, the majority of the memorization work will be completed, “...language itself is a memory aid – there are certain ways to say certain things. Once you definitely know the sequence of thoughts, the words tend to take care of themselves.”²⁰⁶ All that is left to do is to go over the text to make certain it is memorized verbatim.

Of course this method will be valuable for the parish pastor in memorizing sermons where a verbatim memorization of the sermon may not be desirable, but rather a ‘thought for thought’ memorization so the sermon does not sound stilted or memorized.

IX. Conclusion

As we have seen, the usage of mnemonics was an invention of necessity prior the printing press in order to preserve knowledge and to pass on the faith to the next generation in the Church. For the Israelites, remembrance always began with God, and then in turn, man remembered the LORD and His gracious works and covenant with man.

Memory and remembrance not only looks backwards, but forwards. As the Hebrews anticipated the Messiah, so we too remember the future in anticipation for the Lord’s triumphant return.

²⁰⁶ Ibid., 54.

The massive increase in knowledge, proliferation in information and a desire to 'blaze new trails' in thought and research versus the ancients ideal of preserving and passing on knowledge has all but destroyed our need for a 'mechanical' functioning memory essential for preservation of knowledge in an oral society.²⁰⁷

By taking a dismissive attitude to learn anything "by heart" (memorize) as childish and primitive we desire to 'move beyond' what is known and certain (i.e. 'simple') to the speculative too soon. Luther is dismayed by such high-minded attitudes. In the 1530 preface of his LC he writes, "Think of it! In one hour we can finish learning what God Himself cannot finish teaching..."

Henry Nouwen comments on the necessity of meditation and 'learning by heart' the Word of God for ministers:

How then can we be spiritual people through whom God's divine counselor and guide can become manifest?...the word of God must be engraved in our hearts; it must become our flesh and blood. That means much more than intellectual reflection. It means meditating on God's word...I fear that in crisis situations I will have to depend on my own unredeemed ramblings and not have the word of God to guide me.²⁰⁸

While parroting Scripture in and of itself is of little value, a continued meditation on Scripture provides a paradigm in which all reality is filtered and understood. Learning Scripture "by heart" through meditation (an oral process) always leads to a *new* and *deeper* understandings of Scripture in its own time, and to whom it testifies - Jesus Christ. Luther says in the 1530 Preface of his Large Catechism, "In such reading, conversation, and meditation the Holy Spirit is present and bestows ever new and greater light and devotion..."

Luther again comments in his *Large Catechism* under the Third Command:

²⁰⁷ Morris, 113-115.

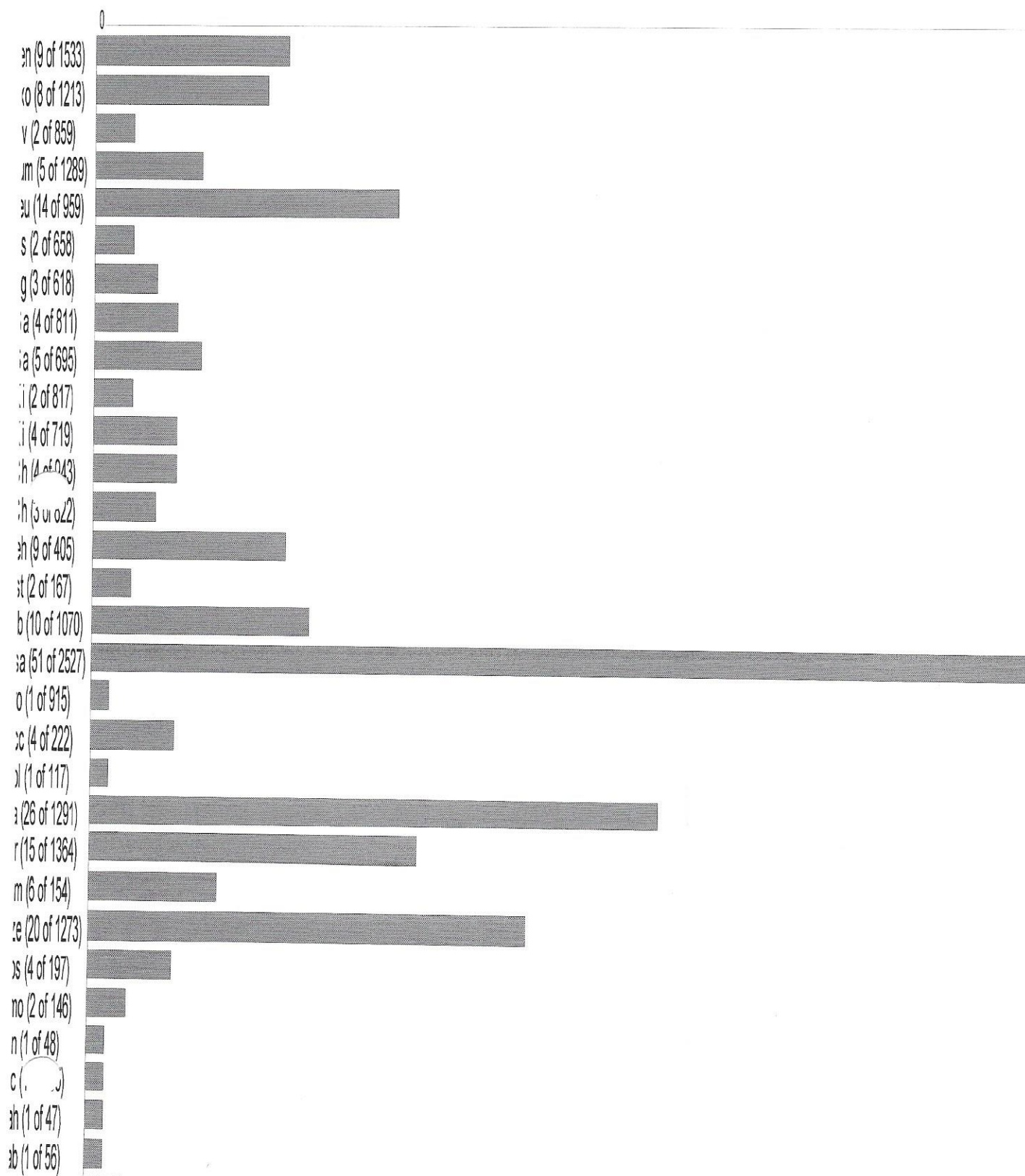
²⁰⁸ Nouwen, Henri J. M. *The Living Reminder: Service and Prayer in Memory of Jesus Christ*. ([San Francisco]: HarperSanFrancisco, 1998), 68, 70.

Indeed, we Christians ought to observe an ongoing holy day and be totally involved with holy things, that is, daily occupy ourselves with God's Word, carrying it in our hearts and on our lips...learn it and remember it [emphasis mine].²⁰⁹

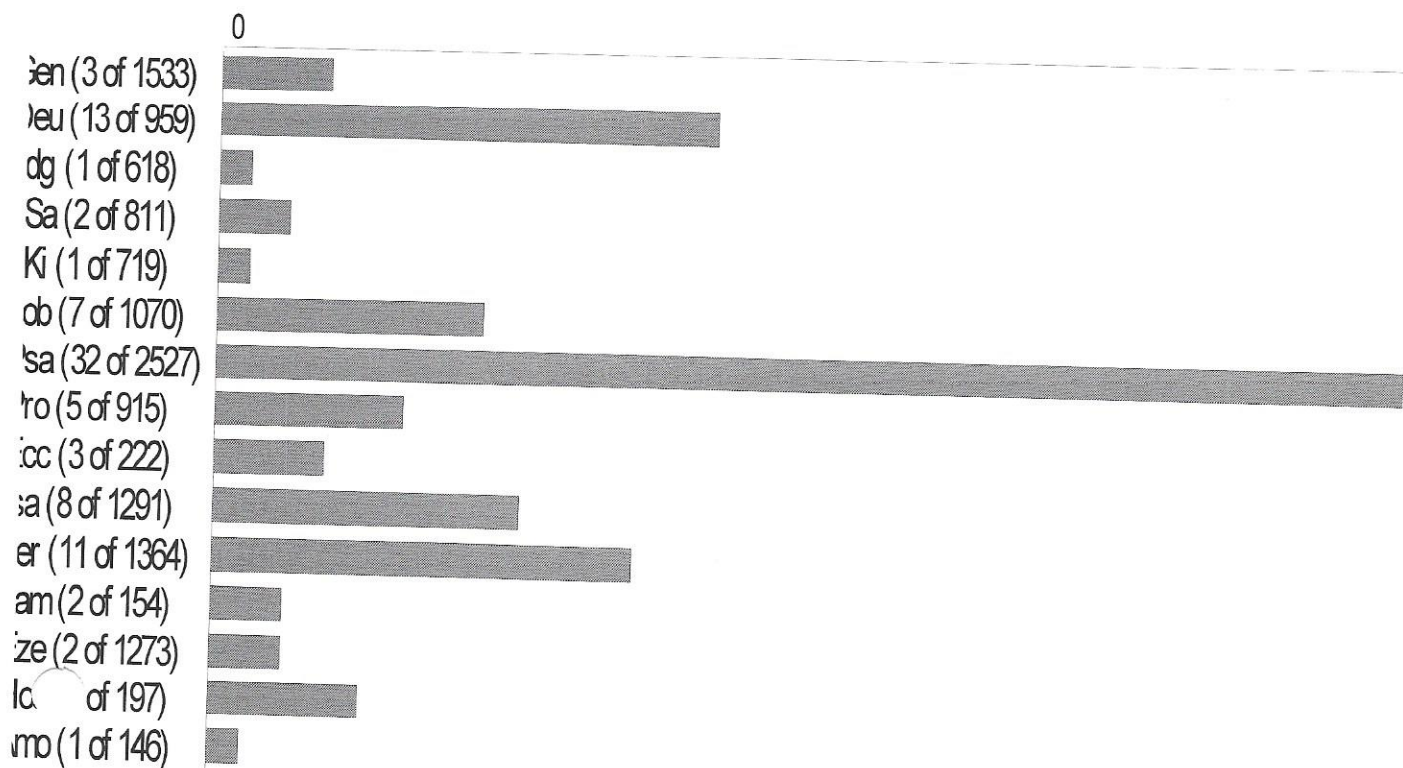
By using the techniques of mnemonics, it is less toilsome for students to appropriate and carry the Word of God with them for a lifetime. By having the Small Catechism memorized, the laity will have a lens or paradigm with which to understand and exegete memorized Scripture in an orthodox Lutheran fashion.

²⁰⁹ LC I 89, 98

APPENDIX A
GRAPHIC TABLE OF THE USAGE OF זכר IN OLD TESTAMENT



APPENDIX A-1
 GRAPHIC TABLE OF THE USAGE OF שָׁכָה IN OLD TESTAMENT



APPENDIX B

ILLUSTRATION OF MNEMONIC MODELS

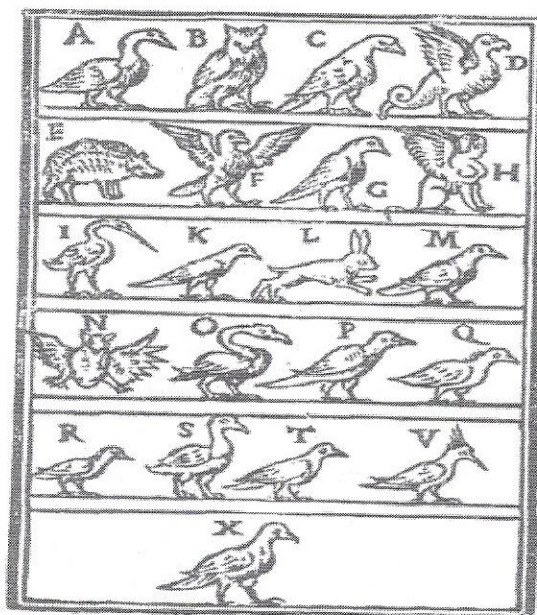


Figure 1. Romberch's Visual Alphabet, 1533.

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